

CHESS MASTERY LIBRARY | FIRST EDITION

How to Train and Review Games

A feedback loop that makes knowledge available over the board

THE PROMISE

Build training around active recall, representative positions, and evidence from your own games.

VOLUME 14 OF 15

READ | RECALL | DECIDE | RETEST

What this volume should change

- Separate learning, testing, and feedback.
- Review games before engine use and convert errors into future decisions.
- Use spaced and mixed practice without turning chess into clerical work.

HOW TO STUDY

Read one section. Close the PDF and state its decision rule from memory. Solve the position lab before viewing the answer. Revisit the lab after two days and again after one week.

Inside this volume

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This volume is an original teaching synthesis of established chess ideas. Positions marked illustrative are designed to isolate a decision, not to replace full-game analysis. Board diagrams use Colin M. L. Burnett's Cburnett piece artwork from Lichess, licensed GPLv2+.

Active study produces an answer

Passive reading and video can build orientation, but improvement requires producing something: a move, candidate list, evaluation, plan, or explanation. Generation makes the gap visible and gives feedback a target.

Position cues

- Predict the next move before revealing it.
- Explain why the natural alternative fails.
- Reconstruct a position from a short description.
- State the cue and decision rule from memory tomorrow.

PRACTICE RULE

Convert every study item into a prompt with a delayed answer. If the material cannot be tested, reduce it to one question that can.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

Recognition while reading is not recall. Familiarity creates confidence faster than skill.

Review your game without an engine first

Your unaided review reveals the reasoning that produced the moves. Mark moments of uncertainty, candidate choices, evaluation changes, clock pressure, and emotional reactions. Only then use an engine or reference to test the chess.

Position cues

- First uncertainty: where understanding ended.
- Critical decision: where choices diverged meaningfully.
- Error cause: perception, candidate generation, calculation, evaluation, or knowledge.
- Transfer rule: what you will notice or do next time.

PRACTICE RULE

Annotate with words before variations. A short honest thought such as 'I never considered their check' is high-value data.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

Starting with the engine can replace your thought with its moves and hide the cause you need to train.

Use engines as diagnostic instruments

An engine answers what works, but training needs why you missed it. Compare your candidates with the engine's, test the best defensive reply, and explore enough to understand the changed evaluation. Keep the smallest useful lesson.

Position cues

- If the best move was absent: candidate-generation problem.
- If present but rejected: calculation or evaluation problem.
- If chosen for the wrong reason: fragile success needing clarification.
- If many moves work: avoid overlearning a noncritical detail.

PRACTICE RULE

Turn analysis into a card: position, prompt, your error, better reasoning, and retry date.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

Do not memorize engine lines beyond the point needed to explain the idea and refute your candidate.

Spaced repetition for chess positions

Retry positions after forgetting has begun. A simple schedule is two days, one week, three weeks, and two months, shortened after errors. Spacing is useful only if the prompt requires the same skill you want in games.

Position cues

- Tactical card: find the move and calculate all defenses.
- Positional card: evaluate, list candidates, choose a plan.
- Opening card: recall the reason, threat, and resulting structure.
- Endgame card: state the result and mechanism before moving.

PRACTICE RULE

Retire cards that are repeatedly easy and replace them with representative errors from newer games.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

Do not build a collection so large that reviewing it replaces playing and analysis.

Mix skills after initial learning

Blocked practice helps you understand a new pattern, but mixed practice tests recognition. A real game does not announce 'fork puzzle' or 'rook ending.' Once a motif is understood, mix it with non-tactical and defensive positions.

Position cues

- Learn a motif in a short focused set.
- Then mix it with other motifs and quiet positions.
- Include positions where the tempting tactic does not work.
- Score the decision process, not puzzle speed alone.

PRACTICE RULE

For every three motif exercises, include one 'nothing tactical works' position that rewards evaluation or prophylaxis.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

Endless themed puzzles can teach you that a combination must exist, a cue absent from real games.

A sustainable weekly loop

The best plan is one you can run for months. Combine serious play, game review, targeted positions, and a small amount of conceptual reading. Adjust the balance from evidence, not guilt.

Position cues

- Play: two or more games slow enough to think.
- Review: unaided first, tools second, one lesson per game.
- Drill: short daily position work from recurring errors.
- Read: one or two library sections tied to current weaknesses.
- Test: revisit old positions and look for transfer in new games.

PRACTICE RULE

At week's end, answer: What error repeated? What improved? What single training change follows?

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

Do not redesign the entire program after one bad session or a short rating swing.

Position Lab

Do not turn the page until you have written a candidate list or explanation. Score the process separately from whether your final answer is correct.

LAB 01

Your engine says a move is +2.0, but you never considered it. What is the most useful first question?

BEFORE CHECKING

Name the cue, list at least two candidates or explanations, and test the strongest objection.

LAB 02

You solve a tactical card correctly for the fourth time in a row. What should happen next?

BEFORE CHECKING

Name the cue, list at least two candidates or explanations, and test the strongest objection.

Position Lab - Answers

LAB 01

Ask what visible feature should have generated the move as a candidate. The evaluation number identifies a gap; the trigger and candidate process create a trainable correction.

LAB 02

Lengthen the interval or retire it, then replace it with a fresh representative error. Repeated easy recall has diminishing returns.

Daily Study Card

Use this as a compact recall sheet. Say each item without looking, then open the volume only for the item you cannot explain.

- Produce an answer before consuming one.
- Review your thought process before engine analysis.
- Classify the cause, not only the move.
- Retry representative positions after a delay.
- Let new games determine the next study target.

TRANSFER TEST

During your next five serious games, mark every position where this volume's cue appeared. Improvement means you noticed the cue and used a better process, even when the game result was noisy.

CONTINUE WITH

01_Checklists_Glossary_and_Study_Map.pdf

Personal notes